

poverty. In fact, it may be said that the novel suffers most painfully from an overdose of simplistic neo-Orientalist structures, particularly surprising from an established travel writer like Theroux. For one would be hard put to assume that the novel's consistently dour, colonialist-essentialist pronouncements on "India", "Calcutta", "foreigners" and natives are actually doled out with an ironic (if dead) hand: and if one is so hard put to decipher it, then clearly the irony has faltered in its stride and the effect is both dead and deadening.

There is much that leaves one squeamish about the novel, and perplexingly enough, the one that causes the least flutter, perhaps, is the dead child's dismembered hand that is obviously exhibit numero uno in this rather non-gripping crime thriller of sorts. Indeed, a corpse rolled in a carpet and thrown into a young man's shabby hotel room in contaminated Calcutta as he sleeps fitfully should certainly be the prime mover and shaker of this tale of Americans abroad. When a suspicion that the same corpse's dead hand makes its way into Delfont's palm to convince him that he must

The novel seems to try pathetically hard to be what it never can be: a post-modern crime drama and an intellectual pirouette on writing.

indeed investigate the crime that the seductive Ma Unger desires him to solve, there should be little doubt left that it is this moving finger, so to speak, that anchors the mystery. However, that it pales into a sordid indifference besides the discomfiting antics of a Kali-worshipping, tantric sex-practising, risqué all-American mother figure who insists on being addressed as Ma as she guides the sexually-aroused Delfont to worship repeatedly at her "lotus" is a measure, I would suggest, of how grossly the novel goes wrong in its primary focus.

Alongside Merrill Unger, a.k.a. Ma, the city of Calcutta is Theroux's faux-protagonist—and here too, astonishingly enough, this established and distinguished travel-writer stumbles and falls on his face as often as he finds himself prone in just such a position on the sexy lady's tantric table. Even as he strews his tale with a fair number of recognisable street and restaurant names to recreate a living city—if not entirely accurately, but with enough veracity to pass muster—Theroux confounds the reader with a succession of ridiculously-sweeping statements about its people and ways that makes one wonder, in fact, if the novel has been ghost-written by some unknown, wanna-be writer called Delfont instead.

Indeed, this might explain the novel's "dead hand" far more thrillingly. ■

Future is Scary

A science fiction veteran imagines India 100 years after Independence

By Dilip Bobb



CYBERABAD DAYS
by IAN McDONALD
Hachette India
Price: Rs 350
Pages: 313

Chandrababu Naidu will be pleased with his effort to turn Hyderabad into Cyberabad. The name now features as the title of a book by one of science fiction's celebrated authors. Ian McDonald's shot to SF fame with his 2004 book, *River of Gods*, on India in 2047, 100 years after Independence. This is a sequel of sorts, but in the form of seven short stories, most having been published as novellas, which blend love, sex and spirituality with technology, war,

politics and the environment. SF is an acquired taste and not everybody can relate to the fantasy world of robots and aliens and arcane jargon. Cyberabad in 2047 is the whole subcontinent and also the virtual universe of aeais (artificial intelligences). India has broken into several warring nations, but still the world's info-tech leader. In seven stories, McDonald traces the changes in India through the evolution of aeais. His battle robots are robotwallahs, the rock stars of future wars, fighting to preserve the new nation of Bharat.

It's a brave new world that's not so hard to imagine. Prolonged drought had led to waterwars and creation of new dynasties. In *The Dust Assassin*, two of these powerful families clash with tragic Romeo and Juliet-type results. The skewed sex ratio underpins *An Eligible Boy*, while the book's centrepiece is *The Djinn's Wife*, in which an aeai and a human fall in love. *Cyberabad Days* includes just one previously unpublished work, *Vishnu at the Cat Circus*, the story of a man genetically engineered to be the future of the human race, but may instead be an evolutionary dead-end. In every tale, there is the thread of a contemporary concern, artificial intelligence, global warming, gender relations, religious dogma and nation-building. McDonald succeeds in weaving the individual tales into a clash of civilisations, Bharat versus India. His Cyberabad is bad and good, depressing and uplifting but always scary and insecure, much like India in 2009. What this collection essentially achieves is to perform the quintessential science fictional magic trick: imagining technological change through personalities. For an Irishman who has spent most of his life in Dublin, McDonald's India is remarkably authentic, even if its future is somewhat scary. ■